Activity 04 - Mediated Conversation at Mosaic Creative

Course: Mastering The Art of Conflict Resolution to Foster Team Collaboration and Success (TGS-2023021752) Duration: 60 minutes Materials: Role cards | mediation record | observer checklist Output: A mediated-conversation record containing ground rules, reframed interests, options and a SMART working agreement.

Objective

Conduct a sensitive mediated conversation using active listening, validation and option generation.

Psychological-safety boundary

Use only the fictional case. Do not require anyone to disclose a personal conflict. Any participant may call a pause or request another role. This learning activity does not replace organisational policy, HR advice or legal advice.

Scenario

At Mosaic Creative, designer Alex says reviewer Taylor undermines ideas in client-preparation meetings by interrupting with risks. Taylor says Alex dismisses feedback and presents concepts too late for proper review. Their manager Jordan will mediate. The shared goal is to improve client work without silencing critique. The issue is appropriate for mediation: there is no current allegation of harassment, discrimination or threat, and both parties agree to participate.

Detailed instructions

Role cards

Give each participant only their own role before the first round. Observers use the checklist.

Jordan | Mediator

Goal: run a fair process. Private brief: Sets ground rules, paraphrases, reframes, reality-tests and records agreement.

Alex | Designer

Goal: receive fair consideration. Private brief: Needs time to explain ideas and feedback focused on work rather than competence.

Taylor | Reviewer

Goal: surface risk early. Private brief: Needs concerns heard and evidence considered before client exposure.

1. Confirm suitability. Jordan checks voluntary participation, readiness, power balance and whether any allegation requires a formal rather than mediated process.

2. Set the room. Choose a private neutral setting, agree a 60-minute boundary and remove avoidable interruptions.

3. State scope and limits. The mediator explains neutrality, respectful conduct, note use and the limits of confidentiality. Parties confirm the issue to discuss.

4. Agree ground rules. Use one speaker at a time, specific recent examples, no insults, permission to pause and a shared focus on future work.

5. Hear Alex. Alex speaks for two minutes. Jordan paraphrases facts, feelings, impact and needs; Taylor listens without rebuttal and then checks understanding.

6. Hear Taylor. Repeat the same sequence and time for Taylor. Jordan avoids deciding whose experience is more legitimate.

7. Reframe blame. Translate accusatory phrases into observable behaviour, impact, interest and a future-focused request.

8. Find common ground. Record the shared goals and the separate interests that any option must satisfy.

9. Generate options. Each party proposes at least two options without evaluation. Then combine, refine and add support that the manager can provide.

10. Reality-test. Check fairness, feasibility, policy fit, workload and what each party will do if the plan begins to fail.

11. Write the agreement. Specify critique timing, uninterrupted presentation time, language expectations, owners, support and a review date.

12. Observer feedback and replay. The observer uses the checklist to identify one strong mediation move and one missed opportunity. Replay a difficult 90-second segment.

Suggested timing

- 6 minutes - Suitability, scope and ground rules
- 10 minutes - Opening accounts
- 10 minutes - Paraphrase and reframe
- 10 minutes - Interests and common ground
- 10 minutes - Options and reality test
- 8 minutes - Working agreement
- 6 minutes - Observer feedback and replay

Discussion questions

- What opening establishes purpose, neutrality and limits of confidentiality?
- How will Jordan validate each perspective without taking sides?
- Which shared interests can move the dialogue beyond positions?
- What specific agreement would change the next design review?

Submission

Submit the completed worksheet and checklist. Use role names rather than real personal data, mark unresolved information as unknown and retain the artefact only through the approved course channel.

Debrief

The role play completes the CLEAR cycle and produces a balanced, observable and reviewable agreement.